TINY JAPANESE · WORKBOOK

Hiragana Starter

Read every hiragana character in 11 short lessons.

Absolute beginner · 11 lessons · Reading & writing

How to use this workbook. Follow the lessons on the website (with the short video for each one), and keep this workbook next to you. Read each page, say everything out loud, do the writing practice and tick your answers in "Check yourself". The answer key is at the back.

Website: tiny-japanese.sabagh1.workers.dev

LESSON 1 OF 11 · 15 MIN

Meet Hiragana: The Vowels

Goal: By the end you can read and say the five vowels and a handful of real Japanese words.

Three scripts, one language

Japanese is written with three scripts that work together. Hiragana is the first one you learn: 46 simple characters that cover every sound in the language. Katakana is a second set of characters, used mainly for foreign words and names. Kanji are characters borrowed from Chinese that carry meaning.

We start with hiragana because it is the base for everything else. Beginner lessons, children's books, and the readings printed above kanji all use it.

Good news: hiragana is regular. One character is one syllable, and it is always pronounced the same way. There is no spelling chaos like English.

The five vowels

あ	い	う	え	お
a	i	u	e	o

How to say them

あ — a
Like the “a” in “father”. Open your mouth fully.

い — i
Like the “ee” in “see”, but short.

う — u
Like the “oo” in “moon”, but with relaxed lips: don't push them forward.

え — e
Like the “e” in “bed”.

お — o
Like the “o” in “more”. Keep it steady; don't let it glide into “oh-oo”.

Your first words

JAPANESE	ROMAJI	MEANING
あい	ai	love
いえ	ie	house
うえ	ue	above, on top

あお	ao	blue
いいえ	iie	no
ええ	ee	yes

Spot the difference

あ and お look alike at a glance. Look at them side by side in the chart and write each a few times. After a day or two the shapes stop being confusing.

How to practise

- Say each sound out loud as you read it. Reading silently is much slower for building memory.
- Write each new character about ten times on paper, following the stroke order from a reliable chart. Writing helps you notice the small differences between similar characters.
- Cover the romaji column and try to read the characters, then check yourself. This is what the quiz at the end of every lesson does too.

Writing practice

Trace the grey characters, then write each one on your own. Say the sound out loud every time. Check the stroke order in this lesson's video.

a	あ	あ	あ						
i	い	い	い						
u	う	う	う						
e	え	え	え						
o	お	お	お						

Check yourself

1. How do you read う?

◯ A. a ◯ B. e ◯ C. u

2. How do you read お?

◯ A. o ◯ B. u ◯ C. a

3. How do you read え?

◯ A. i ◯ B. a ◯ C. e

4. Which character is “a”?

◯ A. お ◯ B. い ◯ C. あ

5. Which character is “i”?

◯ A. え ◯ B. い ◯ C. お

6. What does うえ mean?

◯ A. above, on top ◯ B. house ◯ C. love

7. What does あい mean?

◯ A. house ◯ B. no ◯ C. love

8. How do you read いいえ?

◯ A. ue ◯ B. ao ◯ C. iie

9. Which of the three Japanese scripts do you learn first?

◯ A. Hiragana ◯ B. Kanji ◯ C. Katakana

LESSON 2 OF 11 · 15 MIN

The K Row: か き く け こ

Goal: Read か き く け こ and combine them with the vowels to read simple words.

How the chart works

Hiragana is organised in rows. Each row keeps the same consonant and runs through the five vowels in the same order: a, i, u, e, o. Learn the K row and you know five new characters in one go.

The K row

か	き	く	け	こ
ka	ki	ku	ke	ko

Words you can read now

JAPANESE	ROMAJI	MEANING
かお	kao	face
あき	aki	autumn
いけ	ike	pond
こえ	koe	voice
えき	eki	station
いく	iku	to go
あかい	akai	red

Notes

- えき (eki) means “station”, one of the first words in the Tiny Japanese stories. If you've done our “At the Station” lesson you've already met it.
- く looks a bit like a “<” and け is a good one to watch: compare it to は when you reach the H row.
- Try writing any short word you know with the hiragana you have learned so far.

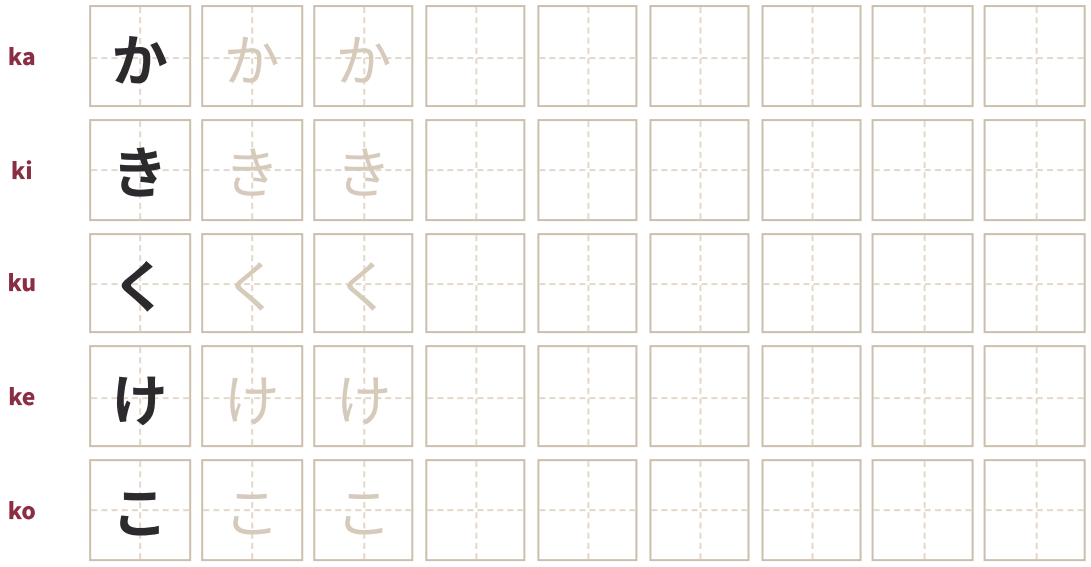
How to practise

- Say each sound out loud as you read it. Reading silently is much slower for building memory.
- Write each new character about ten times on paper, following the stroke order from a reliable chart. Writing helps you notice the small differences between similar characters.

- Cover the romaji column and try to read the characters, then check yourself. This is what the quiz at the end of every lesson does too.

Writing practice

Trace the grey characters, then write each one on your own. Say the sound out loud every time. Check the stroke order in this lesson's video.



Check yourself

1. How do you read く?

◯ A. ku ◯ B. u ◯ C. e

2. How do you read か?

◯ A. ke ◯ B. ka ◯ C. i

3. How do you read こ?

◯ A. ko ◯ B. a ◯ C. o

4. Which character is “a”?

◯ A. い ◯ B. あ ◯ C. お

5. Which character is “u”?

◯ A. う ◯ B. え ◯ C. こ

6. What does いく mean?

◯ A. to go ◯ B. pond ◯ C. autumn

7. What does あかい mean?

◯ A. station ◯ B. voice ◯ C. red

8. How do you read いけ?

◯ A. koe ◯ B. akai ◯ C. ike

LESSON 3 OF 11 · 15 MIN

The S Row: さ し す せ そ

Goal: Read さ し す せ そ, including the special sound “shi”.

The S row

さ	し	す	せ	そ
sa	shi	su	se	so

Two things to watch

し is “shi”, not “si”
In the chart the S row has one irregular sound: し is read “shi”, as in “sheep”. This is why the word すし is written “sushi”.

す is a soft “su”
In everyday speech the final “u” in す is often almost silent. です (desu) sounds like “dess”, and ます (masu) like “mass”. You'll hear this all the time in polite Japanese.

Words you can read now

JAPANESE	ROMAJI	MEANING
あさ	asa	morning
いす	isu	chair
すし	sushi	sushi
せき	seki	seat
うそ	uso	lie
かさ	kasa	umbrella
しお	shio	salt
あし	ashi	foot, leg
すき	suki	like, fond of
さけ	sake	rice wine, alcohol

Notes

- さけ (sake) is really two different words that sound the same: 酒 (“alcohol, rice wine”) and 鮭 (“salmon”). Written in hiragana they look identical, so context tells you which one is meant.
- さ and ち (coming next lesson) are easy to mix up. Compare them side by side before you move on.

How to practise

- Say each sound out loud as you read it. Reading silently is much slower for building memory.
- Write each new character about ten times on paper, following the stroke order from a reliable chart. Writing helps you notice the small differences between similar characters.
- Cover the romaji column and try to read the characters, then check yourself. This is what the quiz at the end of every lesson does too.

Writing practice

Trace the grey characters, then write each one on your own. Say the sound out loud every time. Check the stroke order in this lesson's video.

sa	さ	さ	さ						
shi	し	し	し						
su	す	す	す						
se	せ	せ	せ						
so	そ	そ	そ						

Check yourself

1. How do you read す?

◯ A. su ◯ B. sa ◯ C. so

2. How do you read き?

◯ A. sa ◯ B. ki ◯ C. ko

3. How do you read そ?

◯ A. ka ◯ B. ko ◯ C. so

4. Which character is “shi”?

◯ A. き ◯ B. し ◯ C. こ

5. Which character is “ke”?

◯ A. そ ◯ B. か ◯ C. け

6. What does すし mean?

◯ A. umbrella ◯ B. sushi ◯ C. rice wine, alcohol

7. What does あし mean?

◯ A. umbrella ◯ B. like, fond of ◯ C. foot, leg

8. How do you read あさ?

◯ A. ashi ◯ B. sushi ◯ C. asa

9. How is し pronounced?

◯ A. chi ◯ B. si ◯ C. shi

LESSON 4 OF 11 · 15 MIN

The T Row: た ち つ て と

Goal: Read た ち つ て と and the sounds “chi” and “tsu”.

The T row

た	ち	つ	て	と
ta	chi	tsu	te	to

Two special sounds

ち is “chi”
Like the start of “cheese”. It is not “ti”.

つ is “tsu”
Like the “ts” at the end of “cats”, followed by “oo”. Practise saying just “ts” first, then add the vowel. English speakers often turn it into “su” or “too”, so listen for the quick “ts” at the start.

Words you can read now

JAPANESE	ROMAJI	MEANING
たこ	tako	octopus
つき	tsuki	moon
くち	kuchi	mouth
て	te	hand
とけい	tokei	clock, watch
うち	uchi	home, inside
あした	ashita	tomorrow
たかい	takai	high, expensive
ちかい	chikai	near

Notes

- あした (ashita) means “tomorrow” and you'll use it in the greetings lesson of our conversation course: また あした, “see you tomorrow”.

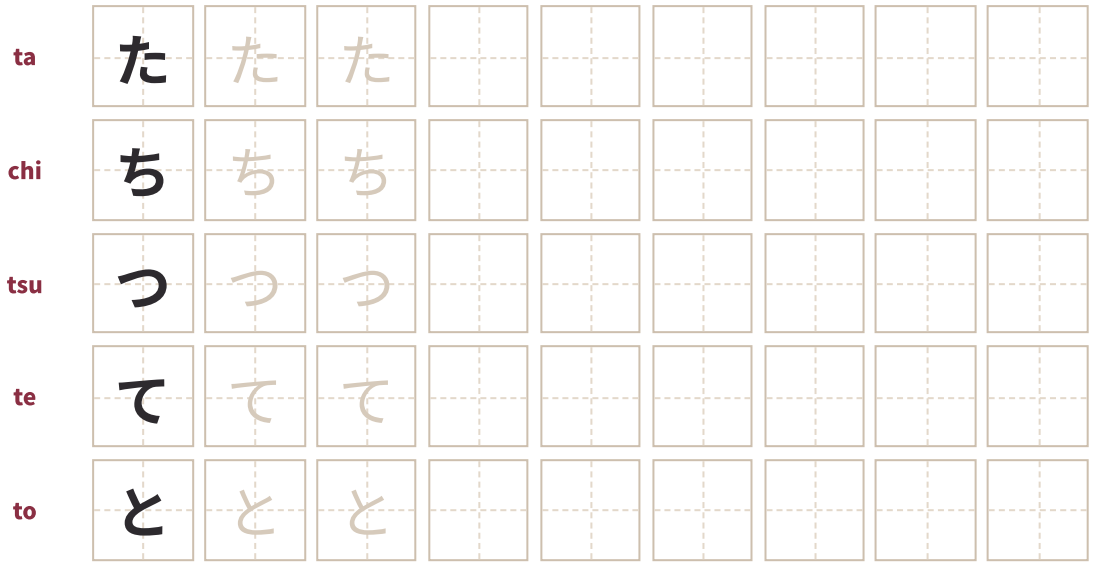
- たかい (takai) can mean both “tall/high” and “expensive”. Same word, and the meaning comes from context.

How to practise

- Say each sound out loud as you read it. Reading silently is much slower for building memory.
- Write each new character about ten times on paper, following the stroke order from a reliable chart. Writing helps you notice the small differences between similar characters.
- Cover the romaji column and try to read the characters, then check yourself. This is what the quiz at the end of every lesson does too.

Writing practice

Trace the grey characters, then write each one on your own. Say the sound out loud every time. Check the stroke order in this lesson's video.



Check yourself

1. How do you read せ?

◯ A. tsu ◯ B. se ◯ C. so

2. How do you read つ?

◯ A. tsu ◯ B. se ◯ C. sa

3. How do you read し?

◯ A. to ◯ B. se ◯ C. shi

4. Which character is “te”?

◯ A. ち ◯ B. て ◯ C. す

5. Which character is “to”?

◯ A. と ◯ B. つ ◯ C. ち

6. What does て mean?

◯ A. near ◯ B. mouth ◯ C. hand

7. What does とけい mean?

◯ A. clock, watch ◯ B. near ◯ C. hand

8. How do you read たかい?

◯ A. ashita ◯ B. tsuki ◯ C. takai

9. Which of these is the correct reading of つ?

◯ A. su ◯ B. tsu ◯ C. tu

LESSON 5 OF 11 · 15 MIN

The N Row: な に ぬ ね の

Goal: Read な に ぬ ね の and know what の does in a sentence.

The N row

な	に	ぬ	ね	の
na	ni	nu	ne	no

Words you can read now

JAPANESE	ROMAJI	MEANING
ねこ	neko	cat
いぬ	inu	dog
なつ	natsu	summer
にく	niku	meat
さかな	sakana	fish
なに	nani	what
あなた	anata	you
たのしい	tanoshii	fun, enjoyable
ぬの	nuno	cloth

A first particle: の

の links two nouns
の works like the English “'s”. You'll see it everywhere: わたしの means “my”, and in later lessons you'll use patterns like “Mika's book”. For now just know that の is a tiny word that links things together.

Notes

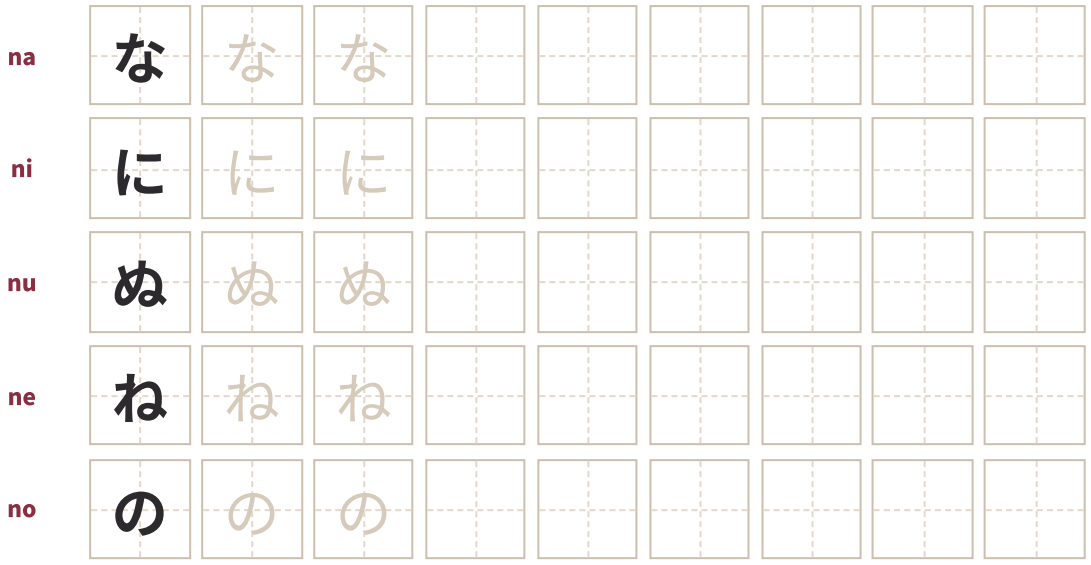
- ぬ and め (next to learn) are similar, as are ね, れ and わ. When you reach those you'll know why. Always compare characters side by side rather than learning one at a time.
- なに (nani) means “what?”. It is one of the most useful question words you will ever learn.

How to practise

- Say each sound out loud as you read it. Reading silently is much slower for building memory.
- Write each new character about ten times on paper, following the stroke order from a reliable chart. Writing helps you notice the small differences between similar characters.
- Cover the romaji column and try to read the characters, then check yourself. This is what the quiz at the end of every lesson does too.

Writing practice

Trace the grey characters, then write each one on your own. Say the sound out loud every time. Check the stroke order in this lesson's video.



Check yourself

1. How do you read て?

◯ A. to ◯ B. chi ◯ C. te

2. How do you read ね?

◯ A. nu ◯ B. ni ◯ C. ne

3. How do you read な?

◯ A. na ◯ B. no ◯ C. te

4. Which character is “chi”?

◯ A. て ◯ B. ち ◯ C. つ

5. Which character is “no”?

◯ A. に ◯ B. と ◯ C. の

6. What does いぬ mean?

◯ A. dog ◯ B. you ◯ C. cloth

7. What does ねこ mean?

◯ A. you ◯ B. cat ◯ C. what

8. How do you read あなた?

◯ A. nani ◯ B. anata ◯ C. natsu

LESSON 6 OF 11 · 15 MIN

The H Row: は ひ ふ へ ほ

Goal: Read は ひ ふ へ ほ and know when は and へ change their sound.

The H row

は	ひ	ふ	へ	ほ
ha	hi	fu	he	ho

Two special sounds

ふ is “fu”
Not a sharp English “f”. Blow softly as if you were cooling soup, with your lips nearly together. That is the Japanese “fu”.

は and へ as particles
When は marks the topic of a sentence it is read “wa”, not “ha”. When へ marks a direction (“to”) it is read “e”, not “he”. Everywhere else they keep their normal reading. You'll see this in almost every sentence you read.

Words you can read now

JAPANESE	ROMAJI	MEANING
はな	hana	flower
ひと	hito	person
ふね	fune	ship, boat
ほし	hoshi	star
はし	hashi	chopsticks
ふく	fuku	clothes
ひくい	hikui	low
へた	heta	unskilled, poor at
ほしい	hoshii	want

Notes

- あなたは (anata wa) is read “anata wa”, and えきへ いく (eki e iku) means “go to the station”. Notice how は and へ change sound in these.
- は and ほ are close. ほ has an extra stroke, so compare them side by side.

How to practise

- Say each sound out loud as you read it. Reading silently is much slower for building memory.
- Write each new character about ten times on paper, following the stroke order from a reliable chart. Writing helps you notice the small differences between similar characters.
- Cover the romaji column and try to read the characters, then check yourself. This is what the quiz at the end of every lesson does too.

Writing practice

Trace the grey characters, then write each one on your own. Say the sound out loud every time. Check the stroke order in this lesson's video.



Check yourself

1. How do you read へ?

◯ A. ha ◯ B. he ◯ C. hi

2. How do you read ひ?

◯ A. hi ◯ B. ne ◯ C. ho

3. How do you read は?

◯ A. ha ◯ B. ho ◯ C. na

4. Which character is “ho”?

◯ A. へ ◯ B. ほ ◯ C. ぬ

5. Which character is “fu”?

◯ A. ふ ◯ B. ひ ◯ C. ほ

6. What does へた mean?

◯ A. person ◯ B. chopsticks ◯ C. unskilled, poor at

7. What does ふく mean?

◯ A. unskilled, poor at ◯ B. flower ◯ C. clothes

8. How do you read ひと?

◯ A. hito ◯ B. hana ◯ C. fuku

9. In あなたは, how is the last character は read?

◯ A. ha ◯ B. wa ◯ C. ba

10. How is へ read when it means “to” (a direction particle)?

◯ A. e ◯ B. fu ◯ C. he

LESSON 7 OF 11 · 20 MIN

The M and Y Rows

Goal: Read ま み む め も や ゆ よ and the words that use them.

The M row

ま	み	む	め	も
ma	mi	mu	me	mo

The Y row

や	ゆ	よ
ya	yu	yo

Why the Y row is short

Hiragana has only three Y characters. The “yi” and “ye” sounds are not part of the standard set, so the row has gaps, shown empty in the chart above.

Words you can read now

JAPANESE	ROMAJI	MEANING
うみ	umi	sea
あめ	ame	rain
め	me	eye
みみ	mimi	ear
もも	momo	peach
やま	yama	mountain
ゆき	yuki	snow
ゆめ	yume	dream
やすみ	yasumi	rest, day off
まいにち	mainichi	every day
むし	mushi	insect

Notes

- あめ (ame) means “rain”. The same spelling can also mean “candy”, which is said with a different pitch. Context tells you which.
- ぬ and め look alike. So do ね, れ and わ (soon). Compare them side by side and write each a few times.
- まいにち (mainichi) is a great word to remember: it means “every day”, which is the pace we suggest for these lessons.

How to practise

- Say each sound out loud as you read it. Reading silently is much slower for building memory.
- Write each new character about ten times on paper, following the stroke order from a reliable chart. Writing helps you notice the small differences between similar characters.
- Cover the romaji column and try to read the characters, then check yourself. This is what the quiz at the end of every lesson does too.

Writing practice

Trace the grey characters, then write each one on your own. Say the sound out loud every time. Check the stroke order in this lesson's video.

ma	ま	ま	ま						
mi	み	み	み						
mu	む	む	む						
me	め	め	め						
mo	も	も	も						
ya	や	や	や						
yu	ゆ	ゆ	ゆ						
yo	よ	よ	よ						

Check yourself

1. How do you read め?

◯ A. hi ◯ B. me ◯ C. yu

2. How do you read よ?

◯ A. yu ◯ B. hi ◯ C. yo

3. How do you read ゆ?

◯ A. yu ◯ B. yo ◯ C. ya

4. How do you read ほ?

◯ A. ma ◯ B. fu ◯ C. ho

5. Which character is “he”?

◯ A. へ ◯ B. ま ◯ C. め

6. Which character is “mi”?

◯ A. よ ◯ B. み ◯ C. は

7. What does め mean?

◯ A. snow ◯ B. eye ◯ C. rest, day off

8. What does あめ mean?

◯ A. insect ◯ B. eye ◯ C. rain

9. How do you read みみ?

◯ A. yasumi ◯ B. yuki ◯ C. mimi

LESSON 8 OF 11 · 20 MIN

The R Row, わ, を and ん

Goal: Read ら り る れ ろ, わ, を and ん, and finish all 46 basic hiragana.

The R row

ら ra	り ri	る ru	れ re	ろ ro

わ, を and ん

わ wa	を o	ん n

Things to know

The R sound sits between R and L
Japanese “r” is made by lightly tapping the tip of your tongue behind your upper teeth, a bit like the “tt” in the American “butter”. It is neither an English “r” nor a clear “l”.

を is the object particle
を is pronounced “o” and is used almost only as a grammar particle. It marks what the action is done to: ほんを よむ (hon o yomu) means “read a book”.

ん is a syllable on its own
ん is the only hiragana that is not a vowel or a consonant+vowel. It's a nasal “n” that takes a full beat, as in にほん (ni-ho-n).

Words you can read now

JAPANESE	ROMAJI	MEANING
さくら	sakura	cherry blossom
くるま	kuruma	car
ほん	hon	book
みかん	mikan	mandarin orange
わたし	watashi	I, me
からて	karate	karate

いろ	iro	colour
ろく	roku	six
れもん	remon	lemon
にほん	nihon	Japan

Notes

- わたしは ほんを よむ — “I read a book”. Every character in this sentence is now readable. Try reading it out loud, with は as “wa” and を as “o”.
- る and ろ are close, and so are ね, れ and わ. Compare them in the charts above.
- You now know all 46 basic hiragana! Next up are the sound-change marks, which multiply what you can read.

How to practise

- Say each sound out loud as you read it. Reading silently is much slower for building memory.
- Write each new character about ten times on paper, following the stroke order from a reliable chart. Writing helps you notice the small differences between similar characters.
- Cover the romaji column and try to read the characters, then check yourself. This is what the quiz at the end of every lesson does too.

Writing practice

Trace the grey characters, then write each one on your own. Say the sound out loud every time. Check the stroke order in this lesson's video.

ra	ら	ら	ら					
ri	り	り	り					
ru	る	る	る					
re	れ	れ	れ					
ro	ろ	ろ	ろ					
wa	わ	わ	わ					

o を を を

n ん ん ん

Check yourself

1. How do you read を?

◯ A. o ◯ B. ro ◯ C. ri

2. How do you read め?

◯ A. ro ◯ B. me ◯ C. mu

3. How do you read る?

◯ A. ro ◯ B. ru ◯ C. me

4. How do you read ら?

◯ A. ru ◯ B. mi ◯ C. ra

5. Which character is “wa”?

◯ A. を ◯ B. ん ◯ C. わ

6. Which character is “re”?

◯ A. れ ◯ B. を ◯ C. も

7. What does わたし mean?

◯ A. six ◯ B. mandarin orange ◯ C. I, me

8. What does みかん mean?

◯ A. mandarin orange ◯ B. lemon ◯ C. karate

9. How do you read いろ?

◯ A. watashi ◯ B. iro ◯ C. nihon

10. How is the particle を pronounced?

◯ A. o ◯ B. wo ◯ C. u

LESSON 9 OF 11 · 20 MIN

Dakuten and Handakuten: が ざ だ ば ぱ

Goal: Add the two small sound marks to characters you know and read the new sounds.

Two small marks

You don't need to learn 25 new characters. You only need two marks. Adding dakuten (two small strokes, as in が) makes a consonant “voiced”: か (ka) becomes が (ga). Adding handakuten (a small circle, as in ぱ) to the H row makes the P sounds: は (ha) becomes ぱ (pa).

G row (from K)

が ga	ぎ gi	ぐ gu	げ ge	ご go

Z row (from S)

ざ za	じ ji	ず zu	ぜ ze	ぞ zo

D row (from T)

だ da	ぢ ji	づ zu	で de	ど do

B row (from H)

ば ba	び bi	ぶ bu	べ be	ぼ bo

P row (from H, with a circle)

ぱ pa	ぴ pi	ぷ pu	ぺ pe	ぽ po

Things to know

Sound changes to remember
し (shi) becomes じ (ji). ち (chi) becomes ぢ (ji). つ (tsu) becomes づ (zu). ふ (fu) becomes ぶ (bu). Check the charts above for each of these.

ぢ and づ are rare
ぢ sounds the same as じ, and づ sounds the same as ず. They only appear in a few words (for example つづく, “to continue”). You can read じ and ず and you'll be fine nearly all the time.

Don't mix up the two marks
ば (ba) and ぱ (pa) differ only by the mark. Look for two small strokes (ば) or a small circle (ぱ) before you read.

Words you can read now

JAPANESE	ROMAJI	MEANING
ありがとう	arigatou	thank you
ごはん	gohan	cooked rice, meal
かばん	kaban	bag
てがみ	tegami	letter
さんぽ	sanpo	walk, stroll
ぱん	pan	bread
たべもの	tabemono	food
まど	mado	window
でぐち	deguchi	exit
すごい	sugoi	amazing
りんご	ringo	apple
ともだち	tomodachi	friend
ひらがな	hiragana	hiragana

Notes

- ありがとう (arigatou) means “thank you”, one of the first words many learners pick up, and now you can read it.
- ひらがな (hiragana) is itself written in hiragana, of course.

How to practise

- Say each sound out loud as you read it. Reading silently is much slower for building memory.
- Write each new character about ten times on paper, following the stroke order from a reliable chart. Writing helps you notice the small differences between similar characters.

- Cover the romaji column and try to read the characters, then check yourself. This is what the quiz at the end of every lesson does too.

Writing practice

Trace the grey characters, then write each one on your own. Say the sound out loud every time. Check the stroke order in this lesson's video.

ga	が	が	が						
gi	ぎ	ぎ	ぎ						
gu	ぐ	ぐ	ぐ						
ge	げ	げ	げ						
go	ご	ご	ご						
za	ざ	ざ	ざ						
ji	じ	じ	じ						
zu	ず	ず	ず						
ze	ぜ	ぜ	ぜ						
zo	ぞ	ぞ	ぞ						
da	だ	だ	だ						
de	で	で	で						
do	ど	ど	ど						
ba	ば	ば	ば						

bi	び	び	び						
bu	ぶ	ぶ	ぶ						
be	べ	べ	べ						
bo	ぼ	ぼ	ぼ						
pa	ぱ	ぱ	ぱ						
pi	ぴ	ぴ	ぴ						
pu	ぷ	ぷ	ぷ						
pe	ぺ	ぺ	ぺ						
po	ぽ	ぽ	ぽ						

Check yourself

1. How do you read ず?

◯ A. ge ◯ B. zu ◯ C. bi

2. How do you read で?

◯ A. ji ◯ B. bo ◯ C. de

3. How do you read ば?

◯ A. gi ◯ B. ba ◯ C. bu

4. How do you read ぞ?

◯ A. bi ◯ B. zo ◯ C. ze

5. Which character is “pu”?

◯ A. ば ◯ B. が ◯ C. ぷ

6. Which character is “da”?

◯ A. だ ◯ B. じ ◯ C. げ

7. Which character is “ze”?

◯ A. ぴ ◯ B. ご ◯ C. ぜ

8. What does たべもの mean?

◯ A. food ◯ B. window ◯ C. amazing

9. What does かばん mean?

◯ A. bag ◯ B. friend ◯ C. bread

10. How do you read すごい?

◯ A. deguchi ◯ B. sugoi ◯ C. mado

11. What does adding dakuten (two small strokes) to か change it into?

◯ A. か (kaa) ◯ B. き (ki) ◯ C. が (ga)

12. What does adding handakuten (a small circle) to は make?

◯ A. ば (ba) ◯ B. ぱ (pa) ◯ C. わ (wa)

LESSON 10 OF 11 · 25 MIN

Combined Sounds, Small っ and Long Vowels

Goal: Read combined sounds like きょ, double consonants with small っ, and long vowels.

Three last ideas

You now know every character. Three small rules fill in the rest of the picture: small ゃ ゅ ょ make combined sounds, small っ doubles a consonant, and long vowels last twice as long.

Combined sounds

きゃ kya	きゅ kyu	きょ kyo
しゃ sha	しゅ shu	しょ sho
ちゃ cha	ちゅ chu	ちょ cho
にゃ nya	にゅ nyu	にょ nyo
ひゃ hya	ひゅ hyu	ひょ hyo
みゃ mya	みゅ myu	みょ myo
りゃ rya	りゅ ryu	りょ ryo
ぎゃ gya	ぎゅ gyu	ぎょ gyo
じゃ ja	じゅ ju	じょ jo
びゃ bya	びゅ byu	びょ byo
ぴゃ pya	ぴゅ pyu	ぴょ pyo

How combos work

Small ゃ ゅ ょ blend into one syllable
き + ゃ makes きゃ, read “kya” as one beat. Compare ひや (hi-ya, two beats) with ひゃ (hya, one beat). The small size is what tells you to blend.

Spelling hints

しゃ しゅ しょ are “sha shu sho”, ちゃ ちゅ ちょ are “cha chu cho” and じゃ じゅ じょ are “ja ju jo”. They follow the spellings of し, ち and じ.

Small っ: a short pause

っ doubles the next consonant

A small っ is not a sound on its own. It tells you to hold the next consonant for an extra beat, like a tiny stop. きて (kite, “come”) vs きって (kitte, “stamp”), and がっこう (gakkou, “school”).

Long vowels

Stretch the vowel for two beats

あ, い, う after the same vowel makes it long: おかあさん (okaasan), おにいさん (oniisan), ゆうめい (yuumei).

え and お sounds

A long お sound is usually written with う, as in ありがとう and おとうさん, and sometimes with お, as in おおきい (ookii). A long え sound is usually written with い, as in せんせい (sensei).

Length changes meaning

おばさん (obasan, “aunt”) and おばあさん (obaasan, “grandmother”) differ only by one stretched vowel. Hold long vowels for twice as long.

Words you can read now

JAPANESE	ROMAJI	MEANING
きょう	kyou	today
しゃしん	shashin	photo
ちょっと	chotto	a little
がっこう	gakkou	school
ざっし	zasshi	magazine
きって	kitte	postage stamp
おちゃ	ocha	tea
ひゃく	hyaku	one hundred
りょこう	ryokou	trip, travel
びょういん	byouin	hospital
でんしゃ	densha	train

おかあさん	okaasan	mother
おにいさん	oniisan	older brother
ゆうめい	yuumei	famous
おおきい	ookii	big

How to practise

- Say each sound out loud as you read it. Reading silently is much slower for building memory.
- Write each new character about ten times on paper, following the stroke order from a reliable chart. Writing helps you notice the small differences between similar characters.
- Cover the romaji column and try to read the characters, then check yourself. This is what the quiz at the end of every lesson does too.

Check yourself

1. How do you read ちゃ?

◯ A. cha ◯ B. hyu ◯ C. ju

2. How do you read しょ?

◯ A. sho ◯ B. nyo ◯ C. cha

3. How do you read ちゅ?

◯ A. chu ◯ B. myo ◯ C. gyu

4. How do you read りゃ?

◯ A. bya ◯ B. cha ◯ C. rya

5. How do you read にょ?

◯ A. gyo ◯ B. byo ◯ C. nyo

6. Which character is “ryo”?

◯ A. じょ ◯ B. ぴゃ ◯ C. りょ

7. Which character is “gya”?

◯ A. びゃ ◯ B. ぎゃ ◯ C. びゅ

8. What does ちょっと mean?

◯ A. famous ◯ B. postage stamp ◯ C. a little

9. What does でんしゃ mean?

◯ A. school ◯ B. train ◯ C. older brother

10. What does がっこう mean?

◯ A. school ◯ B. mother ◯ C. hospital

11. How do you read ゆうめい?

◯ A. hyaku ◯ B. chotto ◯ C. yuumei

12. How do you read ざっし?

◯ A. kyou ◯ B. zasshi ◯ C. shashin

13. What does the small っ in きって tell you to do?

◯ A. Say the vowel twice ◯ B. Raise your voice ◯ C. Hold the next consonant for an extra beat
◯ D. Skip the next character

14. Which of these is ONE beat, not two?

◯ A. ひや ◯ B. ひい ◯ C. ひあ ◯ D. ひゃ

15. How is おかあさん read?

◯ A. okaasen ◯ B. okaasan ◯ C. okasan

LESSON 11 OF 11 · 25 MIN

Reading Practice and Review

Goal: Read hiragana words and short sentences aloud with confidence.

You can read hiragana

You now know the whole system. This lesson is for practice: words you'll see in real life, and simple sentences. Read each aloud first, then check the romaji and meaning.

Places and everyday words

JAPANESE	ROMAJI	MEANING
とうきょう	**toukyou**	Tokyo
きょうと	**kyouto**	Kyoto
おおさか	**oosaka**	Osaka
ふじさん	**fujisan**	Mt. Fuji
にほんご	**nihongo**	the Japanese language
おいしい	**oishii**	delicious
すみません	**sumimasen**	excuse me, sorry
おはようございます	**ohayou gozaimasu**	good morning (polite)
こんにちは	**konnichiwa**	hello
ごちそうさまでした	**gochisousama deshita**	thank you for the meal

Sentences to read aloud

Sentence 1
これは ほんです。
Kore wa hon desu.
This is a book.

Sentence 2
きょうは あついです。
Kyou wa atsui desu.
It's hot today.

Sentence 3
ねこが すきです。
Neko ga suki desu.
I like cats.

Sentence 4	すしを たべます。 **Sushi o tabemasu.** I eat sushi.
Sentence 5	えきは どこですか。 **Eki wa doko desu ka.** Where is the station?
Sentence 6	ひらがなが よめます！ **Hiragana ga yomemasu!** I can read hiragana!

Where to go next

Katakana is the second script, used for foreign words, names and many food and drink names. It follows exactly the same sound chart you have just learned, only with different shapes, so the hard part is already done.

To use your new reading skills straight away, start the First Conversations course. Its dialogues are written in hiragana and katakana, with romaji and English alongside.

Check yourself

1. How do you read きょうと?

◯ A. kiyouto ◯ B. kyotto ◯ C. kyouto

2. What does おいしい mean?

◯ A. delicious ◯ B. tomorrow ◯ C. expensive

3. In これは ほんです, how is は read?

◯ A. ba ◯ B. ha ◯ C. wa

4. How is ごちそうさまでした read?

◯ A. gochiso sama desuta ◯ B. gochisosama deshita ◯ C. gochisousama deshita

5. What does すしを たべます mean?

◯ A. Where is the sushi? ◯ B. I eat sushi ◯ C. I like sushi

6. Which sentence means “Where is the station?”

◯ A. えきは どこですか。 ◯ B. ねこが すきです。 ◯ C. これは ほんです。

7. How is ひらがなが よめます read?

◯ A. hiragana ga yomemasu ◯ B. hiragana wa yomemasu ◯ C. hiragana ga yomimasu

Answer key

Lesson 1: Meet Hiragana: The Vowels

1. C. u
2. A. o
3. C. e
4. C. あ
5. B. い
6. A. above, on top
7. C. love
8. C. iie
9. A. Hiragana

Lesson 2: The K Row: か き く け こ

1. A. ku
2. B. ka
3. A. ko
4. B. あ
5. A. う
6. A. to go
7. C. red
8. C. ike

Lesson 3: The S Row: さ し す せ そ

1. A. su
2. B. ki
3. C. so
4. B. し
5. C. け
6. B. sushi
7. C. foot, leg
8. C. asa
9. C. shi

Lesson 4: The T Row: た ち つ て と

1. B. se
2. A. tsu
3. C. shi
4. B. て
5. A. と
6. C. hand
7. A. clock, watch
8. C. takai
9. B. tsu

Lesson 5: The N Row: な に ぬ ね の

1. C. te
2. C. ne
3. A. na
4. B. ち
5. C. の
6. A. dog
7. B. cat
8. B. anata

Lesson 6: The H Row: は ひ ふ へ ほ

1. B. he
2. A. hi
3. A. ha
4. B. ほ
5. A. ふ
6. C. unskilled, poor at
7. C. clothes
8. A. hito
9. B. wa
10. A. e

Lesson 7: The M and Y Rows

1. B. me
2. C. yo
3. A. yu
4. C. ho
5. A. へ
6. B. み
7. B. eye
8. C. rain
9. C. mimi

Lesson 8: The R Row, わ, を and ん

1. A. o
2. B. me
3. B. ru
4. C. ra
5. C. わ
6. A. れ
7. C. I, me
8. A. mandarin orange
9. B. iro
10. A. o

Lesson 9: Dakuten and Handakuten: が ざ だ ば ぱ

1. B. zu
2. C. de
3. B. ba
4. B. zo
5. C. ぷ
6. A. だ
7. C. ぜ
8. A. food
9. A. bag
10. B. sugoi
11. C. が (ga)
12. B. ぱ (pa)

Lesson 10: Combined Sounds, Small っ and Long Vowels

1. A. cha
2. A. sho
3. A. chu
4. C. rya
5. C. nyo
6. C. りょ
7. B. ぎゃ
8. C. a little
9. B. train
10. A. school
11. C. yuumei
12. B. zasshi
13. C. Hold the next consonant for an extra beat
14. D. ひゃ
15. B. okaasan

Lesson 11: Reading Practice and Review

1. C. kyouto
2. A. delicious
3. C. wa
4. C. gochisousama deshita
5. B. I eat sushi
6. A. えきは どこですか。
7. A. hiragana ga yomemasu

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